Table 7.1 Relative atomic mass of elements (C-12 Scale)

Element	Symbol	A_r
Hydrogen	H	1
Carbon	C	12
Nitrogen	N	14
Oxygen	O	16
Sodium	Na	23
Magnesium	Mg	24
Sulphur	S	32



Relative Atomic Mass is only a ratio, so it has no unit. If the atomic mass of an element is expressed in grams, it is called as **Gram Atomic Mass**

Gram Atomic Mass of hydrogen = 1 g

Gram Atomic Mass of carbon = 12 g

Gram Atomic Mass of nitrogen = 14 g

Gram Atomic Mass of oxygen = 16 g

7.1.2 Average Atomic Mass (AAM)

How can one measure the atomic mass of an element? It is somewhat more complicated because most of the naturally occuring elements exist as a mixture of isotopes, each of which has its own mass. Thus, it is essential to consider this isotopic mixture while calculating the atomic mass of an element.

The average atomic mass of an element is the weighted average of the masses of its naturally occurring isotopes.

But, the abundance of isotopes of each element may differ. So, the abundancy of all these isotopes are taken into consideration while calculating the atomic mass. Then, what do we mean by a weighted average? Let us consider an element which exists as a mixture of 50% of an isotope having a mass of 9 amu, and 50% of another isotope having a mass of 10 amu. Then, its average atomic mass is calculated by the following equation:

Average atomic mass

= (Mass of 1st isotope × % abundance of 1st isotope) + (Mass of 2nd isotope × % abundance of 2nd isotope)

Thus, for the given element the average

$$\text{atomic mass} = (9 \times \frac{50}{100}) + (10 \times \frac{50}{100})$$

$$= 4.5 + 5 = 9.5 \text{ amu}$$

(Note: In the calculations involving percentages, you need to convert percentage abundance into fractional abundance. For example, 50 percent is converted into 50/100 or 0.50 as shown in the a foresaid calculation.)

The atomic masses of elements, given in the periodic table, are average atomic masses. Sometimes, the term atomic weight is used to mean average atomic mass. It is observed, from the periodic table that atomic masses of most of the elements are not whole numbers. For instance, the atomic mass of carbon given in the periodic table is 12.01 amu, not 12.00 amu. The reason is that while calculating the atomic mass of carbon, both of its natural isotopes such as carbon-12. and carbon-13 are considered. The natural abundance of C-12 and C-13 are 98.90 % and 1.10 % respectively. The average of the atomic mass of carbon is calculated as follows:

Average atomic mass of carbon

$$= (12 \times \frac{98.9}{100}) + (13 \times \frac{1.1}{100})$$

$$= (12 \times 0.989) + (13 \times 0.011)$$

$$= 11.868 + 0.143 = 12.011 \text{ amu}$$

So it is important to understand that if it is mentioned that the atomic mass of carbon is 12 amu, it refers to the average atomic mass of the carbon isotopes, not the mass of the individual atoms of carbon.

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